Mexican Poetry Collection

By Jimmy Santiago Baca, Bill Dahl and Rafael Guillen

INTRODUCTION

According to USA Today: "Most of the estimated 6.3 million Mexicans who are in the USA illegally came because of family connections and better job opportunities here, not because they were unemployed or destitute in their homeland.". And therein lies part of the issue: the vast majority of American citizens believe that illegal immigrants from Mexico are taking away our jobs. The statistics tend to prove this perception; however, as with every issue, there are two sides that should be heard. Jimmy Santiago Baca presents a view from south of the border in "So Mexicans are Taking Jobs from Americans"

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So Mexicans are Taking Jobs from Americans

O Yes? Do they come on horses
with rifles, and say,

Ese gringo, gimmee your job?

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And do you, gringo, take off your ring,
drop your wallet into a blanket
spread over the ground, and walk away?

I hear Mexicans are taking your jobs away.
Do they sneak into town at night,
and as you're walking home with a whore,
do they mug you, a knife at your throat,
saying, I want your job?

Even on TV, an asthmatic leader
crawls turtle heavy, leaning on an assistant,
and from a nest of wrinkles on his face,
a tongue paddles through flashing waves
of lightbulbs, of cameramen, rasping
"They're taking our jobs away."

Well, I've gone about trying to find them,
asking just where the hell are these fighters.
The rifles I hear sound in the night
are white farmers shooting blacks and browns

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whose ribs I see jutting out
and starving children,
I see the poor marching for a little work,
I see small white farmers selling out
to clean-suited farmers living in New York,
who've never been on a farm,
don't know the look of a hoof or the smell
of a woman's body bending all day long in fields.

I see this, and I hear only a few people
got all the money in this world, the rest
count their pennies to buy bread and butter.

Below that cool green sea of money,
millions and millions of people fight to live,
search for pearls in the darkest depths
of their dreams, hold their breath for years
trying to cross poverty to just having something.

The children are dead already. We are killing them,
that is what America should be saying;

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on TV, in the streets, in offices, should be saying,
"We aren't giving the children a chance to live."

Mexicans are taking our jobs, they say instead.
What they really say is, let them die,
and the children too.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jimmy Santiago Baca
Book: Immigrants in our Own Land
ISBN: 978-0811211451
Publisher: New Directions Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1990

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier

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TRANSITION

Immigration is now and always has been a tricky affair. The delicate balance of need and want, verses can and should. We can certainly understand someone living in desperate conditions wanting to improving their lot in life. What better place to do it than the greatest nation on earth. America is the envy of the world. We are a magnet, and a beacon. After all . . "Give us your poor, your tired, your huddled masses longing to be free..."is engraved at the base of the Statue of Liberty. Before you make your final decision on the issue of immigration (legal or otherwise), ask yourself a simple question. What would you do if you were in their place, but first, take a long look around your home, in you fridge and in your pantry.. and just for an added effect, and take an extra moment thinking of your children. Perhaps, you'll come away with a slightly different outlook. Immigrace-un by Bill Dahl

Immigrace-un

Unconvinced, we can't let *them* in.

Uncertain what to do with sin.

Unsettled because *they* are here.

Undue stress of misdirected fear.

Unbelievable, the insensitivity of man.

Unwilling to do all we can.

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Unconscious of the opportunity to rise above,

Unjust policies that can be slain with love.

Unswerving loyalty to a partisan creed.

Unabated cries of those in need.

Undisturbed, is how we prefer to live.

Unconscionable, man's inability to forgive.

Unbalanced adoration of power and might.

Uncomfortable adjustments required to do what's right.

Uncertain about the legitimacy of a border fence and gate.

Unbearable guilt over ungodly hate.

Unearth in us, the will to stand tall.

Unspeakable injustice harms us all.

Unfortunate inequities cast a vast pall.

Unfounded self-righteousness blinds us all.

Under the lies, truth has a face.

Uncommon courage, it's name is *Grace*.

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Underscore the urgency in this nation.

Undo the injustice of **Immigrace-un**.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bill Dahl
Book: Immigration Law Weekly
ISBN: Magazine
Publisher: Immigration Law Weekly
Date (Month/Year): January 8, 2007

TRANSITION

Illegal immigrants are in some ways the lowest of the low in the modern world. Not only do they start over, usually with limited resources; they have a difficult, sometimes expensive and dangerous task getting to their destination; and then have to find employment. They have to deal with ethnic prejudice, xenophobia, and prejudice against their illegal status: "come over here and take our jobs", "can't speak the language", "sponge off welfare", etc. They may live in fear of arrest and deportation or incarceration. Why would anyone become an illegal immigrant? Because it's better than the alternatives. Not Fear by Rafael Guillen

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Not Fear

Not fear. Maybe, out there somewhere,
the possibility of fear; the wall
that might tumble down, because it's for sure
that behind it is the sea.
Not fear. Fear has a countenance;
It's external, concrete,
like a rifle, a shot bolt,
a suffering child,
like the darkness that's hidden
in every human mouth.
Not fear. Maybe only the brand
of the offspring of fear.

It's a narrow, interminable street
with all the windows darkened,
a thread spun out from a sticky hand,
friendly, yes, not a friend.
It's a nightmare
of polite ritual wearing a frightwig.
Not fear. Fear is a door slammed in your face.

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I'm speaking here of a labyrinth
of doors already closed, with assumed
reasons for being, or not being,
for categorizing bad luck
or good, bread, or an expression
— tenderness and panic and frigidity - for the children
growing up. And the silence.
And the cities, sparkling, empty.
and the mediocrity, like a hot
lava, spewed out over
the grain, and the voice, and the idea.

It's not fear. The real fear hasn't come yet.
But it will. It's the doublethink
that believes peace is only another movement.
And I say it with suspicion, at the top of my lungs.
And it's not fear, no. It's the certainty
that I'm betting, on a single card,
the whole haystack I've piled up,
straw by straw, for my fellow man.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Rafael Guillen
Book: I'm Speaking: Selected Poems
ISBN: 978-0810118515
Publisher: Northwestern University Press
Date (Month/Year): July 2000

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